

France and its emperor, Napoleon III, were more sympathetic to the Southern cause due to its ambitions in Mexico, but it would not act without the British.

Frictions between the Union government and Britain reached their most dangerous point when Captain Charles Wilkes of the USS *San Jacinto* violated international law by detaining two Confederate diplomats traveling from Cuba on a British vessel, the *Trent*. This provoked wild talk on both sides, along with British preparations for a possible war, which neither side wanted. Lincoln supposedly declared “one war at a time” as the guide for his policy and both governments looked for a compromise. In the end, the Confederate diplomats were released, and Washington stated that Wilkes had acted without instructions, instead of giving the full apology that the British had demanded.

The other variable inhibiting British recognition was the continued influence of anti-slavery sentiment in Great Britain. While some British aristocrats had a fondness for the Confederacy, Britain was the home of the modern anti-slavery movement, having abolished slavery in all British territories in 1833. As Northern war goals became increasingly friendly toward emancipation, it grew more difficult for the British government to support an administration whose vice president had declared slavery to be its cornerstone. While the British government remained concerned about the high loss of life caused by the war, the long-term result of Lincoln’s Emancipation Proclamation was to make British intervention all but impossible, because now the war had become an explicit contest between freedom and slavery.